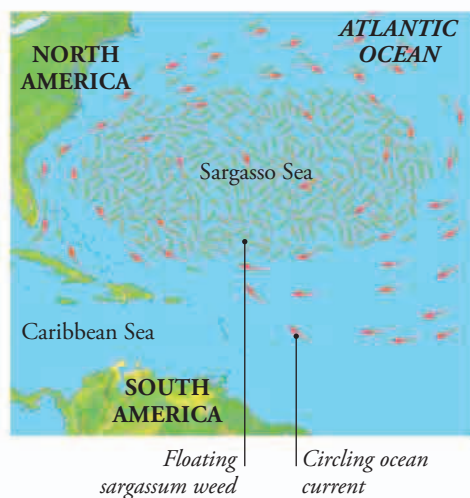


Sargasso Sea

Near the center of the north Atlantic is a region of warm, still water called the Sargasso Sea. It lies in the middle of the surface currents that swirl clockwise around the ocean to the north of the equator. These currents push drifting seaweed into the Sargasso Sea, forming a unique ecosystem of floating marine life.

CIRCLING CURRENTS



The powerful currents of the great oceanic gyres flow around broad areas of water that are not moving at all. Since the flowing surface water pushes deeper water sideways, the currents also drive water into the middle of the gyre. In the north Atlantic, this effect has created the Sargasso Sea.

FLOATING GARDEN

The seaweed that is such a feature of the Sargasso Sea is unusual because it is not attached to rocks, but thrives drifting free on the surface of the deep ocean. Called sargassum weed, it forms a shallow floating garden in the warm water just beneath the waves. Some types have gas-filled bladders on the fronds that act as floats. This layer of drifting seaweed is only a few inches deep, but it is a habitat for several specialized creatures that do not live anywhere else.

EEL NURSERY

The Sargasso Sea is the breeding site for eels that live in European rivers. Adult eels migrate down-river and swim across the ocean to the Sargasso Sea. Here, they lay their eggs, which hatch as tiny leaf-shaped young. They drift on the Gulf Stream current flowing east across the ocean. Eventually, they reach Europe, by which time they have turned into tiny transparent eels.

